Isaac, Jacob, and Joseph

Genesis 25–50

The big idea: God carried his promise through a broken family of favorites, liars, and jealous brothers. He chose Jacob by grace, wrestled him into honesty, and turned the evil done to Joseph into the saving of many lives.

Before you meet: Read

Genesis 25:19–34 | Genesis 28:10–22 | Genesis 32:22–32 | Genesis 37:12–36 | Genesis 50:15–21

Open (5 minutes)

What is one trait or habit that gets passed down in families, good or bad? Where have you seen it happen?

Observe (fill in from the passage)

"Two nations are in your womb… the older shall _____ the younger." *(Genesis 25:23)*

"Behold, I am _____ you and will keep you wherever you go." *(Genesis 28:15)*

"Your name shall no longer be called Jacob, but _____, for you have striven with God and with men, and have prevailed." *(Genesis 32:28)*

They lifted Joseph out of the pit and sold him to the Ishmaelites for twenty shekels of _____. *(Genesis 37:28)*

Judah begged, "Please let your servant remain _____ of the boy as a servant to my lord." *(Genesis 44:33)*

"As for you, you meant _____ against me, but God meant it for _____." *(Genesis 50:20)*

Discuss

1. Why do you think God chose to carry his promise through such a broken family? What encouragement does that give you? *Genesis 25–50*

2. God chose Jacob before he was born, "not because of works but because of him who calls." Why is that good news for people like Jacob, and like us? *Romans 9:11–14*

3. At Bethel Jacob bargained: "If God will be with me… then the LORD shall be my God." Where are you still bargaining with God instead of trusting him? *Genesis 28:15–21*

4. The last time Jacob was asked his name, he lied. At the Jabbok he told the truth. Why does honesty about who we are matter so much in coming to God? *Genesis 27:19; 32:26–30*

5. Judah went from selling his brother to offering himself in his brother's place. What changed him? Where have you seen God change someone like that? *Genesis 37:26–27; 38:26; 44:33*

6. Joseph asked, "Am I in the place of God?" How does trusting God as judge free us to forgive someone who meant us harm? *Genesis 50:19–21*

Apply this week

Think of one thing done against you that still hurts. Pray Genesis 50:20 over it this week: they meant it for evil, and God can mean it for good. When you are tempted to pay someone back, ask yourself Joseph's question: "Am I in the place of God?"

Memory verse

"As for you, you meant evil against me, but God meant it for good."

Genesis 50:20

Pray

Thank God that his promise never depended on the goodness of Abraham's family, or of yours. Ask him to carry you through what others meant for evil, and to give you a heart that forgives because Jesus has forgiven you.

LEADER NOTES · LESSON 7

Isaac, Jacob, and Joseph

Session plan (about 70 minutes)

5 min	Welcome, opening prayer, and the Open question.
10 min	Read Genesis 28:10–22 and 32:22–32 aloud together. Then read 50:15–21.
10 min	Observe: work through the fill-ins together. Use the answer key below.
30 min	Discuss: choose 4 of the 6 questions. Questions 2, 5, and 6 matter most.
5 min	Walk the group through the family diagram in the full lesson: Abraham, Isaac, Jacob, the twelve sons, and Judah's line to David and Jesus.
10 min	Apply and pray. Introduce the memory verse and the reading for Lesson 8 (Exodus 1–3, 12, and 14–15).

Main points to land

1. God keeps his promises through broken people. Genesis 25–50 is full of favoritism, lies, and jealousy, and the promise to Abraham never fails.
2. God chose Jacob before birth, "not because of works but because of him who calls" (Rom. 9:11). Election rests on God's free grace, without any foresight of faith or good works (WCF 3.5).
3. God met Jacob in grace at Bethel before Jacob repented, and broke him at the Jabbok. The grasper became Israel, limping and blessed (Gen. 28:15; 32:28).
4. God's providence rules even over sin. The brothers meant evil and were guilty for it; God meant it for good (Gen. 50:20). Sin comes only from the creature, never from God (WCF 5.4).
5. Joseph and Judah point to Jesus: the rejected brother who saves, and the substitute from Judah, the Lion who conquers as the Lamb (Gen. 44:33; Acts 2:23; Rev. 5:5–6).

Answer key (Observe)

1. serve
2. with
3. Israel
4. silver
5. instead
6. evil; good

Questions people will ask

Jacob got the blessing by lying. Does God reward deceit?
Genesis reports Jacob's sin without approving it. God had already promised before birth that the older would serve the younger (25:23); Rebekah and Jacob grabbed by deceit what God had promised to give. Jacob then spent twenty years being deceived by Laban, and later by his own sons with goat's blood. God kept his promise in spite of Jacob's sin, not because of it.

"Jacob I loved, but Esau I hated." Does God hate people?
Set side by side like this, love and hate are words of choosing (compare Luke 14:26). God set his saving love on Jacob and passed Esau by. No one is owed mercy (Rom. 9:14), and Esau was responsible for despising his birthright (Heb. 12:16). Keep the group on the main point: if God chose people for their goodness, he would never have chosen Jacob.

If God planned it, were the brothers really guilty?
Yes. Joseph says plainly, "you meant evil against me." The same is true at the cross: Jesus was delivered up by God's definite plan, and those who killed him were lawless men (Acts 2:23). Scripture holds both together without explaining every detail, and so does the Confession (WCF 5.4).

Does Romans 8:28 mean the bad things in my life are secretly good?
No. Evil is still evil, and the brothers did evil. Romans 8:28 means God will not let evil done to his people have the last word, and the good he works is making us like his Son (Rom. 8:29). Joseph waited thirteen years to see it. Be gentle with anyone in the group who is still waiting.

Closing prayer

Father, thank you that your promise rests on your grace and not on our families or our goodness. Thank you for choosing sinners, for wrestling us into honesty, and for ruling even the evil done against us for good. Thank you for Jesus, the Brother who was betrayed and who saves. Make us people who forgive as we have been forgiven. Amen.